

me to do some more arithmetic. I figured out that Vicki and I were spending about \$50 a day on our basic living expenses. That's \$50 a day for food and clothes, the maid and dry cleaning, movies and dinner out. It included vacations, golf club dues, guitar lessons, gifts, a cigar now and then, and French cognac. I call that the money we spend on *us*.

There's nothing tricky about this. It's called the \$50-a-Day Rule, and you'll read about it in chapter 8. It's a universal truth, as it turns out. Like the law that every bus station everywhere in the world has a cheap Chinese restaurant nearby; or that when you spill on your tie, it's your favorite tie; or that all accountants are dull.

Fifty dollars a day is an average, not a daily, quota. On trips to New York or Paris you'll need to budget to stay even close to \$50 a day. But in Paraguay or Bangkok or even West Texas you'll find it's hard to spend that much money—unless you're more kinky than my accountant's mind can imagine.

THE \$50-A-DAY RULE

A friend first told me about the \$50-a-Day Rule. (Some of the players in this book are composites, and details have been changed.) He was 42 years old and chief financial officer of a Houston-based oil company when his work life unraveled. The new chairman was acquisition-minded and hammered on the financial staff. Two people on my friend's staff suffered heart attacks; one of them died, and the other was forced to retire. A third had bleeding ulcers; a fourth had high blood pressure.

My friend saw what was happening. "It was crazy," he told me a few years later. "I traveled three days a week to check out companies we wanted to buy. I'd call the office from my hotel room and talk for hours. When I was at home in Houston I'd put in fifteen-hour days. My secretary went into hysterics a couple of times when I gave her things to type. I began to get used to people crying at the office. The place was a zoo."